

utilitarianism

utilitarianism, in normative ethics, a tradition stemming from the late 18th- and 19th-century English philosophers and economists Jeremy Bentham and John Stuart Mill according to which an action (or type of action) is right if it tends to promote happiness or pleasure and wrong if it tends to produce unhappiness or pain—not just for the performer of the action

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English philosopher and economist Jeremy Bentham's preserved skeleton in his own clothes and surmounted by a wax head, at University College London.

but also for everyone else affected by it. Utilitarianism is a species of consequentialism, the general doctrine in ethics that actions (or types of action) should be evaluated on the basis of their consequences. Utilitarianism and other consequentialist theories are in opposition to egoism, the view that each person should pursue his or her own self-interest, even at the expense of others, and to any ethical theory that regards some actions (or types of action) as right or wrong independently of their consequences (see deontological ethics). Utilitarianism also differs from ethical theories that make the rightness or wrongness of an action dependent upon the motive of the agent—for, according to the utilitarian, it is possible for the right thing to be done from a bad motive. Utilitarians may, however, distinguish the aptness of praising or blaming an agent from whether the action was right.

(Read Peter Singer's Britannica entry on ethics.)

The nature of utilitarianism

Utilitarianism is an effort to provide an answer to the practical question “What ought a person to do?” The answer is that a person ought to act so as to maximize happiness or pleasure and to minimize unhappiness or pain.

Basic concepts

In the notion of consequences the utilitarian includes all of the good and bad produced by the action, whether arising after the action has been performed or during its performance. If the difference in the consequences of alternative actions is not great, some utilitarians would not regard the choice between them as a moral issue. According to Mill, acts should be classified as morally right or wrong only if the consequences are of such significance that a person would wish to see the agent compelled, not merely persuaded and exhorted, to act in the preferred manner.

In assessing the consequences of actions, utilitarianism relies upon some theory of intrinsic value: something is held to be good in itself, apart from further consequences, and all other values are believed to derive their worth from their relation to this intrinsic good as a means to an end. Bentham and Mill were hedonists; i.e, they analyzed happiness as a balance of pleasure over pain and believed that these feelings alone are of intrinsic value and disvalue. Utilitarians also assume that it is possible to compare the intrinsic values produced by two alternative actions and to estimate which would have better consequences. Bentham believed that a hedonic calculus is theoretically possible. A moralist, he maintained, could sum up the units of pleasure and the units of pain for everyone likely to be affected, immediately and in the future, and could take the balance as a measure of the overall good or evil tendency of an action. Such precise measurement as Bentham envisioned is perhaps not essential, but it is nonetheless necessary for the utilitarian to make some interpersonal comparisons of the values of the effects of alternative courses of action.

Methodologies

As a normative system providing a standard by which an individual ought to act and by which the existing practices of society, including its moral code, ought to be evaluated and improved, utilitarianism cannot be verified or confirmed in the way in which a descriptive theory can, but it is not regarded by its exponents as simply arbitrary. Bentham believed that only in terms of a utilitarian interpretation do words such as "ought," "right," and "wrong" have meaning and that, whenever people attempt to combat the principle of utility, they do so with reasons drawn from the principle itself. Bentham and Mill both believed that human actions are

motivated entirely by pleasure and pain, and Mill saw that motivation as a basis for the argument that, since happiness is the sole end of human action, the promotion of happiness is the test by which to judge all human conduct.

One of the leading utilitarians of the late 19th century, the Cambridge philosopher Henry Sidgwick, rejected such theories of motivation as well as Bentham's theory of the meaning of moral terms and sought to support utilitarianism by showing that it follows from systematic reflection on the morality of "common sense." Most of the requirements of commonsense morality, he argued, could be based upon utilitarian considerations. In addition, he reasoned that utilitarianism could solve the difficulties and perplexities that arise from the vagueness and inconsistencies of commonsense doctrines.

Most opponents of utilitarianism have held that it has implications contrary to their moral intuitions—that considerations of utility, for example, might sometimes sanction the breaking of a promise. Much of the defense of utilitarian ethics has consisted in answering these objections, either by showing that utilitarianism does not have the implications that its opponents claim it has or by arguing against the opponents' moral intuitions. Some utilitarians, however, have sought to modify the utilitarian theory to accommodate the objections.

Criticisms

One such criticism is that, although the widespread practice of lying and stealing would have bad consequences, resulting in a loss of trustworthiness and security, it is not certain that an occasional lie to avoid embarrassment or an occasional theft from a rich person would not have good consequences and thus be permissible or even required by utilitarianism. But the utilitarian readily answers that the widespread practice of such acts would result in a loss of trustworthiness and security. To meet the objection to not permitting an occasional lie or theft, some philosophers have defended a modification labelled "rule" utilitarianism. It permits a particular act on a particular occasion to be adjudged right or wrong according to whether it is in keeping with or in violation of a useful rule, and a rule is judged useful or not by the consequences of its general practice. Mill has sometimes been interpreted as a "rule" utilitarian, whereas Bentham and Sidgwick were "act" utilitarians.

Another objection, often posed against the hedonistic value theory held by Bentham, holds that the value of life is more than a balance of pleasure over pain. Mill, in contrast to Bentham, discerned differences in the quality of pleasures that make some intrinsically preferable to others independently of intensity and duration (the quantitative dimensions recognized by Bentham). Some philosophers in the utilitarian tradition have recognized certain wholly nonhedonistic values without losing their utilitarian credentials. Thus, the English philosopher G.E. Moore, one of the founders of contemporary analytic philosophy, regarded many kinds of consciousness—including friendship, knowledge, and the experience of beauty—as intrinsically valuable independently of pleasure, a position labelled “ideal” utilitarianism. Even in limiting the recognition of intrinsic value and disvalue to happiness and unhappiness, some philosophers have argued that those feelings cannot adequately be further broken down into terms of pleasure and pain and have thus preferred to defend the theory in terms of maximizing happiness and minimizing unhappiness. It is important to note, however, that, even for the hedonistic utilitarians, pleasure and pain are not thought of in purely sensual terms; pleasure and pain for them can be components of experiences of all sorts. Their claim is that, if an experience is neither pleasurable nor painful, then it is a matter of indifference and has no intrinsic value.

Another objection to utilitarianism is that the prevention or elimination of suffering should take precedence over any alternative act that would only increase the happiness of someone already happy. Some modern utilitarians have modified their theory to require this focus or even to limit moral obligation to the prevention or elimination of suffering—a view labelled “negative” utilitarianism.

Historical survey

The ingredients of utilitarianism are found in the history of thought long before Bentham.

Antecedents of utilitarianism among the ancients

A hedonistic theory of the value of life is found in the early 5th century BCE in the ethics of Aristippus of Cyrene, founder of the Cyrenaic school, and a century later

in that of Epicurus, founder of an ethic of retirement (see Epicureanism), and their followers in ancient Greece. The seeds of ethical universalism are found in the doctrines of the rival ethical school of Stoicism and in Christianity.

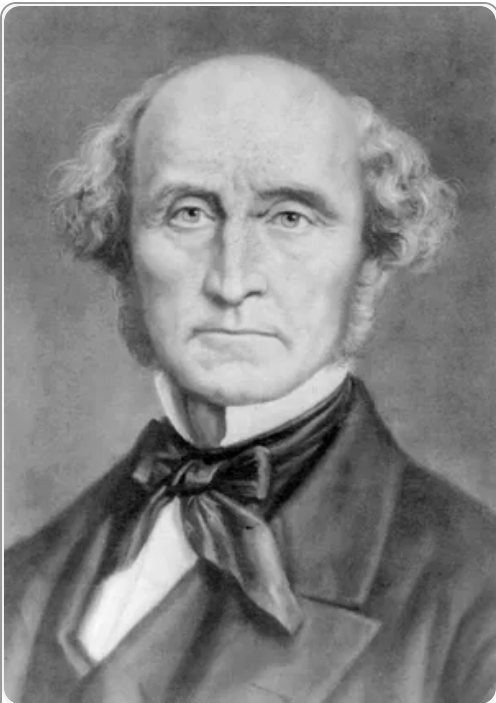
Growth of classical English utilitarianism

In the history of British philosophy, some historians have identified Bishop Richard Cumberland, a 17th-century moral philosopher, as the first to have a utilitarian philosophy. A generation later, however, Francis Hutcheson, a British "moral sense" theorist, more clearly held a utilitarian view. He not only analyzed that action as best that "procures the greatest happiness for the greatest numbers" but proposed a form of "moral arithmetic" for calculating the best consequences. The skeptic David Hume, Scotland's foremost philosopher and historian, attempted to analyze the origin of the virtues in terms of their contribution to utility (see ethics: Hutcheson and Hume). Bentham himself said that he discovered the principle of utility in the 18th-century writings of various thinkers: Joseph Priestley, an English dissenting clergyman famous for his discovery of oxygen; Claude-Adrien Helvétius, the French author of a philosophy of physical sensation; Cesare Beccaria, an Italian legal theorist; and Hume. Helvétius probably drew from Hume and Beccaria from Helvétius.

Another strand of utilitarian thought took the form of a theological ethics. John Gay, an English biblical scholar and philosopher, held the will of God to be the criterion of virtue, but from God's goodness he inferred that God willed that each person should act so as to promote human happiness.

Bentham, who apparently believed that an individual in governing his own actions would always seek to maximize his own pleasure and minimize his own pain, found in pleasure and pain both the cause of human action and the basis for a normative criterion of action. The art of governing one's own actions Bentham called "private ethics." The happiness of the agent is the determining factor; the happiness of others governs only to the extent that the agent is motivated by sympathy, benevolence, or interest in the good will and good opinion of others. For Bentham, the greatest happiness of the greatest number would play a role primarily in the art of legislation, in which the legislator would seek to maximize the happiness of the entire community by creating an identity of interests among all people. By laying

down penalties for mischievous acts, the legislator would make it unprofitable for people to harm their neighbours. Bentham's major philosophical work, *An Introduction to the Principles of Morals and Legislation* (1789), was designed as an introduction to a plan of a penal code.



John Stuart Mill

English philosopher, politician, and social reformer John Stuart Mill, visiting card photograph, 1884.

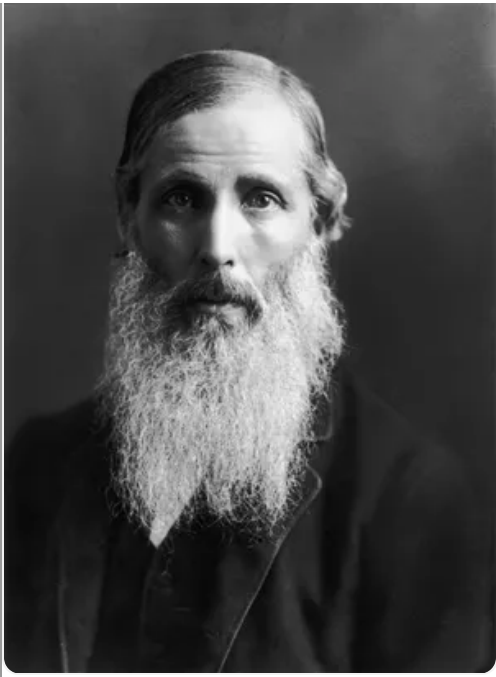
With Bentham, utilitarianism became the ideological foundation of a reform movement, later known as "philosophical radicalism," that would test all institutions and policies by the principle of utility. Bentham attracted as his disciples a number of younger (early 19th-century) intellectuals. They included David Ricardo, who gave classical form to the science of economics; John Stuart Mill's father, James Mill; and John Austin, a legal theorist. James Mill argued for representative government and universal male suffrage on utilitarian grounds; he and other followers of Bentham were advocates of parliamentary reform in England in the early 19th century. John Stuart Mill was a spokesman for woman suffrage, state-supported education for all, and other proposals that were considered

radical in their day. He argued on utilitarian grounds for freedom of speech and expression and for the noninterference of government or society in individual behaviour that did not harm anyone else. Mill's work *Utilitarianism*, originally published in *Fraser's Magazine* (1861), is an elegant defense of the general utilitarian doctrine and perhaps remains the best introduction to the subject. In it utilitarianism is viewed as an ethics for ordinary individual behaviour as well as for legislation.

Utilitarianism since the late 19th century



By the time Sidgwick wrote, utilitarianism had become one of the foremost ethical theories of the day. His *Methods of Ethics* (1874), a



Henry Sidgwick

English philosopher and author Henry Sidgwick.

comparative examination of egoism, the ethics of common sense, and utilitarianism, contains the most careful discussion to be found of the implications of utilitarianism as a principle of individual moral action.

The 20th century saw the development of various modifications and complications of the utilitarian theory. G.E. Moore argued for a set of ideals extending beyond hedonism by proposing that one imaginatively compare universes in which there are equal quantities of pleasure but different amounts of knowledge, friendship, beauty, and other such combinations. He felt that he could not be indifferent toward such differences.

The recognition of “act” utilitarianism and “rule” utilitarianism as explicit alternatives was stimulated by the analysis of moral reasoning in “rule” utilitarian terms by Stephen Toulmin, an English philosopher of science and moralist, and by Patrick Nowell-Smith, a moralist of the Oxford linguistic school; by the interpretation of Mill as a “rule” utilitarian by another Oxford philosopher, J.O. Urmson; and by the analysis by John Rawls, a Harvard political philosopher, of the significance for utilitarianism of two different conceptions of moral rules. “Act” utilitarianism, on the other hand, was defended by J.J.C. Smart, a British-Australian philosopher.

Effects of utilitarianism in other fields

The influence of utilitarianism has been widespread, permeating the intellectual life of the last two centuries. Its significance in law, politics, and economics is especially notable.

The utilitarian theory of the justification of punishment stands in opposition to the “retributive” theory, according to which punishment is intended to make the criminal “pay” for his crime. According to the utilitarian, the rationale of

punishment is entirely to prevent further crime by either reforming the criminal or protecting society from him and to deter others from crime through fear of punishment.

In its political philosophy, utilitarianism bases the authority of government and the sanctity of individual rights upon their utility, thus providing an alternative to theories of natural law, natural rights, or social contract. What kind of government is best thus becomes a question of what kind of government has the best consequences—an assessment that requires factual premises regarding human nature and behaviour.

Generally, utilitarians have supported democracy as a way of making the interest of government coincide with the general interest; they have argued for the greatest individual liberty compatible with an equal liberty for others on the ground that individuals are generally the best judges of their own welfare; and they have believed in the possibility and desirability of progressive social change through peaceful political processes.

With different factual assumptions, however, utilitarian arguments can lead to different conclusions. If one assumes that a strong government is required to check humans' basically selfish interests and that any change may threaten the stability of the political order, one may be led by utilitarian arguments to an authoritarian or conservative position. On the other hand, William Godwin, an English political philosopher of the early 19th century, assumed the basic goodness of human nature and argued that the greatest happiness would follow from a radical alteration of society in the direction of anarchism.

Classical economics received some of its most important statements from utilitarian writers, especially David Ricardo and John Stuart Mill. Ironically, its theory of economic value was framed primarily in terms of the cost of labour in production rather than in terms of the use value, or utility, of commodities. Later developments more clearly reflected the utilitarian philosophy. The English economist William Jevons, one of the founders of the marginal utility school of analysis, derived many of his ideas from Bentham; and "welfare economics," while substituting comparative preferences for comparative utilities, reflected the basic

spirit of the utilitarian philosophy. In economic policy, the early utilitarians had tended to oppose governmental interference in trade and industry on the assumption that the economy would regulate itself for the greatest welfare if left alone; later utilitarians, however, lost confidence in the social efficiency of private enterprise and were willing to see governmental power and administration used to correct its abuses.

As a movement for the reform of social institutions, 19th-century utilitarianism was remarkably successful in the long run. Most of its recommendations were implemented unless abandoned by the reformers themselves, and, equally important, utilitarian arguments were commonly employed to advocate institutional or policy changes.

Summary and evaluation

As an abstract ethical doctrine, utilitarianism has established itself as one of the small number of live options that must be taken into account and either refuted or accepted by any philosopher taking a position in normative ethics. Utilitarianism now appears in various modified and complicated formulations.

Bentham's ideal of a hedonic calculus is usually considered a practical if not a theoretical impossibility. In the 20th century, philosophers noticed further problems in utilitarian procedures. One of them, for example, was with the process of identifying the consequences of an action—a process that raises conceptual as well as practical problems as to what are to be counted as consequences, even without precisely quantifying the value of those consequences. For example, the question may arise whether the outcome of an election is a consequence of each and every vote cast for the winning candidate if that person receives more than the number necessary for election, and, in estimating the value of the consequences, one may ask whether the entire value or only a part of the value of the outcome of the election is to be assigned to each vote. There is also difficulty in the procedure of comparing alternative actions. If one action requires a longer period of time for its performance than another, one may ask whether they can be considered alternatives. Even what is to count as an action is not a matter of philosophical consensus.

These problems, however, are common to almost all normative ethical theories, since most of them recognize the consequences—including the hedonic consequences—of an act as being relevant ethical considerations. The central insight of utilitarianism, that one ought to promote happiness and prevent unhappiness whenever possible, seems undeniable. The critical question, however, is whether the whole of normative ethics can be analyzed in terms of this simple formula.

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